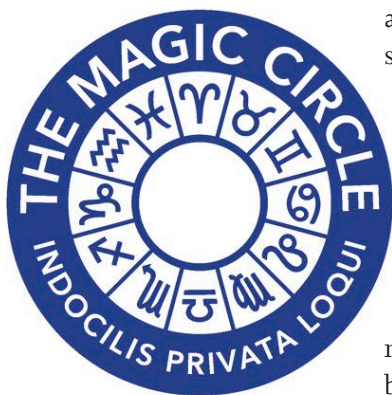


THE TASTE FOR SPECTACLE

magic as modern entertainment

In London in 1921, innovator P.T. Selbit became the first magician to perform what rapidly became a favorite of stage magic: he sawed his female assistant in half. The trick caused a sensation: the world of stage magic went spectacle crazy.

Four decades on, the most flamboyant of all magic acts, the German-born duo of Siegfried and Roy, took Las Vegas by storm. Their trademarks were huge sets, glittering costumes, and wild animals seemingly tamed. Audiences flocked to see them, and magic was big business.



▲ The Magic Circle logo

In 1905, The Magic Circle was founded in London. The Latin motto means “not apt to disclose secrets,” and any member magician who does so is likely to be expelled.

Illusions on screen

American illusionist David Copperfield continued this trend for the spectacular. In a series of stunts broadcast to millions, he appeared to float over the Grand Canyon, walk through the Great Wall of China, saw himself in half with a laser, and make the Statue of Liberty disappear. Copperfield became the richest magician of all time, with a mastery of technology that allowed him to make the apparently impossible possible.

For Copperfield, and the magicians who came after him, television provided a huge audience. The small screen was brilliantly exploited in the UK by Paul Daniels and by the eccentric Tommy Cooper,



▲ Show business meets magic

Siegfried and Roy performed in the American capital of entertainment, Las Vegas, for almost 40 years. Docile white lions and tigers were part of the magical act.

who drolly acted as if he were scarcely in control of his magical tricks. Penn and Teller in the US have also blended comedy with demanding stagecraft, and the standards of magic on screen continue to rise.

Endurance and mentalism

Another American, David Blaine, has pioneered a different kind of magic: that of improbable feats of endurance. These have included surviving in a block of ice, being drowned, and spending 44 days on the banks of London’s Thames River in a plexiglass case with no food. In 2008, he held his breath for more than 17 minutes. Blaine also epitomized the magic of the mentalist—allegedly demonstrating extraordinary mental powers. In his case, rather than mind-reading, he mixed acute psychological insight with sleight of hand.

In the UK, entertainers such as Derren Brown and Dynamo tapped into audiences’ appetite for mentalism. In his television series *The Events*, Brown made inventive use of the medium by including a short film that he claimed could stop viewers from leaving their seats. Dynamo, a magician for the Internet age, took magic online by using YouTube to promote his own brand of mentalism and expert card tricks. He quickly gained a global following.

IN CONTEXT

Escapologists

Ever since Houdini (see p.259), escapology has been a core magic act. In 1959, a Briton, Alan Alan, introduced a twist to Houdini’s straitjacket escapes. He broke free while suspended from a burning rope, a feat since performed by American Dorothy Dietrich (right), who is also the first woman to have performed the “bullet catch in the mouth.” Another American, Robert Gallup, has gone further—he was dropped from a plane, caged and straitjacketed, with his parachute strapped outside. The risks of such stunts are real: in 1990, American Amazing Joe died after being buried in wet cement.

